



ENGL 1102 English Composition 2 Unit 2

Research Modes in Writing

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Rhetorical Modes in Writing: An Overview

In the context of research writing, rhetorical modes serve as essential tools to structure and convey ideas effectively. Each mode has distinct characteristics that cater to specific purposes and audiences.

1. Argumentative Mode

The argumentative mode aims to persuade the audience by presenting a well-reasoned case supported by evidence. It is commonly used in research writing to advocate for a specific position or interpretation. Claims supported by logic, evidence, and analysis, use of credible sources to strengthen arguments, counterarguments addressed to reinforce the writer's stance etc. are some of the features.

In short, **the argumentative mode in research writing is employed to present a thesis or position supported by evidence, aiming to convince readers through logical reasoning.**

Applications in Research:

- Writing position papers or critical analyses.
- Developing research-based arguments in essays and articles.

Example: Research Papers

Example: A research paper arguing for the implementation of renewable energy policies.

Content: The paper presents a clear thesis (e.g., "Renewable energy policies are essential for mitigating climate change"), supports it with data (e.g., statistics on carbon emissions reduction), and addresses counterarguments (e.g., concerns about economic costs or feasibility).

You can read a sample research paper [here](#)

2. Persuasive Mode

The persuasive mode focuses on influencing the audience's emotions, values, and beliefs to adopt the writer's perspective. While it overlaps with argumentative writing, it relies more heavily on



emotional appeal and rhetorical devices. Use of emotional and ethical appeals (pathos and ethos), strong, convincing language and attention to the audience's beliefs and values are some of the characteristic features.

In short, **the persuasive mode in research writing seeks to convince readers to adopt a particular viewpoint, often by appealing to their emotions, values, and ethical considerations alongside logical reasoning.**

Applications in Research:

- Writing persuasive essays, advocacy papers or opinion pieces.
- Persuading stakeholders in proposals and grant applications.

Example 1: Persuasive Essays

An essay urging the adoption of plastic bans to combat ocean pollution.

Content: The author uses vivid imagery to describe the devastating impact of plastic on marine life, appeals to readers' sense of ecological stewardship, and supports the argument with statistical data on plastic waste reduction after bans in other regions.

Example 2: Persuasive Article

A paper/ article advocating for mandatory vaccinations in schools to prevent disease outbreaks.

Content: The writer combines emotional appeals (e.g., stories of families affected by preventable diseases) with factual evidence on vaccine efficacy and ethical arguments about protecting vulnerable populations.

Example 3: Persuasive Research Reports

A report persuading policymakers to adopt stricter emissions standards for industries.

Content: The report appeals to policymakers' sense of responsibility toward future generations, uses persuasive language to highlight the environmental and economic benefits, and includes case studies from countries that successfully implemented similar policies.

You may click the following link to read a sample persuasive essay:

<https://cowriter.ai/blog/persuasive-essay-examples-with-downloadable-pdf>



3. Expository Mode

The expository mode is designed to explain or inform the audience about a particular topic. It emphasizes clarity, logic, and organization without introducing personal opinions. The goal of expository writing is to explain or provide information. It is often broken down into different types, such as classification, evaluation, process, definition, comparison/contrast, and cause/effect (Crowther et al., 2022). Clear, objective presentation of information, logical organization with headings and subheadings, use of examples, definitions, and data to explain concepts are some of the characteristic features.

In summary, **the expository mode in research writing aims to explain or inform the audience about a specific topic without expressing personal opinions or attempting to persuade. It focuses on clarity, objectivity, and a logical presentation of information**

Applications in Research:

- Writing literature reviews, research reports, and instructional manuals.
- Explaining complex theories or methodologies.

Example 1: Literature Reviews

A literature review summarizing existing research on the effects of social media on mental health. Content: The writer provides a clear overview of previous studies, explains their methodologies and findings, and categorizes research into themes (e.g., positive vs. negative effects). The goal is to inform the reader about the state of research in the field without taking a stance on the findings. Click the links below to learn more about writing a literature review:

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/research_and_citation/conducting_research/writing_a_literature_review.html

<https://paperpal.com/blog/academic-writing-guides/what-is-a-literature-review-how-to-write-it-with-examples>

You can read sample literature reviews [here](#)



Example 2: Research Reports

Example: A report on the discovery of a new species of plant in the Amazon rainforest.

Content: The researcher provides detailed descriptions of the plant's physical characteristics, its habitat, and its role in the ecosystem. The aim is to inform readers about the plant, its discovery, and its ecological significance based on factual evidence and observations.

You can click the following links to read sample research reports:

https://www.k-state.edu/fns/assets/course_1/food_for_thought/appendices/Appendix_20.pdf

4. Narrative Mode

The narrative mode uses storytelling to present a sequence of events or experiences. It is often employed in qualitative research and reflective writing to provide context or illustrate a point. Chronological/ thematic organization, use of anecdotes, case studies, or personal experiences, vivid descriptions and details that engage audience are some of the characteristics. Narration is the art of storytelling, and its purpose in writing is to share stories. Whenever you recount an event or experience to a friend or family member, you are engaging in narrative. Narratives can be either factual or fictional. A factual narrative is rooted in real events and strives to accurately represent what happened. On the other hand, a fictional narrative is a created or imagined story, where the writer has the freedom to invent characters and events as they choose (Schmitz, 2012)

In short, **the narrative mode in research writing is used to tell a story or present events in a chronological or thematic order. It is often employed to engage the reader by presenting personal experiences, case studies, or a sequence of events related to the research topic.**

Applications in Research:

- Writing case studies or ethnographic reports.
- Reflective essays or introductions to humanize research topics.

Example 1: Case Studies

A case study on the treatment of a rare medical condition.

Content: The researcher tells the story of a patient's diagnosis, treatment process, and recovery, weaving in clinical data and patient testimonials. The narrative structure allows the researcher to



explain the practical application of theories or medical procedures in a real-world context. You may click the following link to know more about how to write a case study:

<https://www.scribbr.com/methodology/case-study/>

You can read a sample case study [here](#)

Example 2: Reflective Essay: Personal Reflection on a Research Project

Example Topic: "Lessons Learned from My First Research Project in Psychology"

Content: The writer reflects on the challenges and successes of their first research project in psychology. The narrative includes insights on how the writer overcame difficulties such as literature review organization, research design, and time management. The reflective essay emphasizes personal growth and how the experience shaped their approach to future research.

Click the following link to read on how to write a reflective essay:

<https://www.grammarly.com/blog/academic-writing/reflective-essay/>

You can read a sample reflective essay [here](#)

Example 3: Narrative

Example Topic: "A Day in the Life of a Marine Biologist: Observing Coral Reefs"

Content: This narrative recounts a day spent on a research expedition observing coral reefs. The writer describes the environment, the animals observed, and the research methods used. The narrative also highlights personal reflections on the importance of protecting marine ecosystems.

5. Descriptive Mode

The descriptive mode aims to create a vivid image in the reader's mind using sensory details. In research writing, it can enhance engagement by adding depth and texture to data or experiences.

Focus on sensory details (sight, sound, touch, taste, smell), use of figurative language and imagery, precision in describing settings, phenomena, or objects etc. are some of the characteristic features.

In practice, research writing often combines multiple rhetorical modes. For example, a persuasive research article may use expository writing to explain key concepts, descriptive passages to illustrate findings, and argumentative elements to defend its thesis. In short, **the descriptive mode**



in research writing is used to provide vivid, detailed descriptions of a subject, phenomenon, or environment, without offering analysis or interpretation. This mode aims to create a clear and accurate picture for the reader, allowing them to understand the topic through sensory or observational detail.

Applications in Research:

- Describing experiments, environments, or cultural settings.
- Crafting introductions to captivate the reader.

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Example: Describing a Finding

Example Topic: "Weather Patterns Observed in the Arctic During Summer"

Content: A researcher in a field study might describe the weather conditions in the Arctic during the summer months, detailing the temperatures, the clarity of the sky, the occurrence of fog or snow, and the impact of these conditions on the research. This type of description helps the reader visualize the environment in which the research is conducted.

Conclusion

Understanding rhetorical modes enhances a researcher's ability to communicate ideas effectively. By choosing the appropriate mode for the purpose, audience, and context, writers can craft compelling and impactful research documents that resonate with their readers.

Key Takeaways: Rhetorical Modes in Writing

- Rhetorical Modes: Essential tools that help structure research writing to achieve specific purposes and engage different audiences.
- Argumentative Mode: Aims to persuade with logic and evidence, typically used in position papers and critical analyses.



- Persuasive Mode: Influences emotions and beliefs, often found in opinion pieces and advocacy writing.
- Expository Mode: Focuses on explaining or informing without personal opinion, used in literature reviews and research reports.
- Narrative Mode: Tells a story or presents events, often used in case studies and reflective essays.
- Descriptive Mode: Uses sensory details to create vivid images, typically used in experimental or environmental descriptions.
- Combined Usage: Research writing may combine different modes to achieve clarity, persuasion, and engagement.
- Understanding and applying the appropriate rhetorical mode enhances communication and the impact of research writing.

References

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